

B0B04B22 - Anglický jazyk B2-2

WEEK 7

The Difference between Formal and Informal Language*

Reading Comprehension Practice

Knowing **the difference between formal and informal English*** is important for effective communication because it allows you to adapt your language to the appropriate audience and situation, ensuring your message is understood and taken seriously. Using formal English in professional or academic settings demonstrates respect, accuracy, and professionalism, while informal English is suitable for casual interactions with friends and family. The choice between styles affects vocabulary, sentence structure, and tone, and the ability to switch between them is a crucial skill for successful interactions in various social and professional contexts.

What is the difference between formal and informal language?

FORMAL LANGUAGE indicates a dignified and deferential regard (politeness / respect) for the reader / listener. **FORMAL LANGUAGE** is used when communicating / writing for academic, professional and legal purposes.

NOTE: There is such a thing as "SEMI-FORMAL" language (...which is used in day-to-day interaction with colleagues and teachers, and/or when communicating with someone in authority or whom you respect).

SEMI-FORMAL language basically follows ALL the rules of FORMAL language, except:

- *use of phrasal verbs is generally acceptable*
- *use of jargon is generally acceptable (particularly when communicating with someone in the same field)*

INFORMAL LANGUAGE is more casual and spontaneous.

INFORMAL LANGUAGE is used when communicating with friends or family either in writing or speaking.

FORMAL or INFORMAL?

Listed below are the key elements of FORMAL and INFORMAL communication.

Put an **F** in front of those to be used in FORMAL communication and an **I** in front of those to be used in INFORMAL communication.

- (1) ___ avoids repetition and over generalization.
- (2) ___ avoids use of jargon (overly specialized words).
- (3) ___ can use (acceptable) slang and clichés.
- (4) ___ can use imperative sentences.
- (5) ___ does not generally have to follow any rules.
- (6) ___ does not use abbreviations.
- (7) ___ does not use clichés ("...to each his own." "...you win some, you lose some." "...take it or leave it.").
- (8) ___ does not use contractions ("it's" or "won't" BUT "it is" or "will not").
- (9) ___ does not use emotional language.
- (10) ___ does not use spoken phrases ("...let's say..." "...here's how...").
- (11) ___ is loosely structured.
- (12) ___ is more personal and subjective.
- (13) ___ is objective (proper evidence should be there to support any arguments).
- (14) ___ makes limited use of first- and second-person singular pronouns.
- (15) ___ often uses colloquial diction ("gonna" or "shoulda").
- (16) ___ takes the time to ensure all words are used and spelled properly.
- (17) ___ uses contractions, abbreviations and short sentences.
- (18) ___ uses first and second person pronouns.
- (19) ___ uses full and complete sentences.
- (20) ___ uses ordinary, short and simple sentences.
- (21) ___ uses polite word choices and tone.
- (22) ___ uses positive and literal language and academic/professional vocabulary.
- (23) ___ uses proper spelling, grammar and punctuation.
- (24) ___ uses sentences that clearly communicate a thought / idea).

ACRONYMS

The first time an acronym or initialism is used in a piece of writing, it is appropriate to write the name in full, with the acronym or initialism in brackets after it*. Every subsequent time it is used the acronym or initialism can be used on its own. Commonly known acronyms such as the UK and NATO do not need to be written in full. If an acronym or initialism needs to be made into a plural, add a small 's' to it without an apostrophe.

* "...currently studying at the Czech Technical University (CTU) in Prague..."

NOTE: While it IS "the Czech Technical University" it is NOT "~~the~~ CTU"

PRACTICE: Formal and Informal Expressions**[Page 2]**

Fill in the blank spaces in the sentences below (1 - 12) with the appropriate word for a more FORMAL style of communication. Use each of the following words ONLY ONCE. DO NOT change the form of the word.

APPROXIMATE	ARRIVE	AVAILABLE	CATER
CONSEQUENTLY	CONSIDERATION	DEPARTURE	INEQUALITY
INFORMED	LAUGH	OBLIGATION	PRIOR
PURCHASE	RELAXED	REQUIREMENT	SHARP
SHOULD	SHOW	UNDERGO	WORKPLACE

(1) INFORMAL: Come on one of our carefree holidays where you can do your own cooking.

FORMAL: Enjoy the _____ atmosphere of a camping holiday where you can _____ for yourself.

(2) INFORMAL: Don't delay! Thousands of competition prizes are up for grabs!

FORMAL: Thousands of prizes are _____ to anyone who enters the competition before the closing date.

(3) INFORMAL: When my boss spilt coffee down his new suit I just couldn't keep a straight face.

FORMAL: It was difficult not to _____ when my boss spilt coffee down his new suit.

(4) INFORMAL: Because of falling profits, the company may have to lay people off.

FORMAL: The company has reported a _____ decrease in its profits. _____, a number of employees may lose their jobs.

(5) INFORMAL: There are about 30 club members.

FORMAL: The _____ number of club members is 30.

(6) INFORMAL: They haven't made their minds up yet.

FORMAL: The decision is still under _____.

(7) INFORMAL: You have to have a check-up before you start work.

FORMAL: It is a _____ that all employees of the company _____ a medical examination _____ to starting their employment.

(8) INFORMAL: A report says that men and women are not treated the same at work.

FORMAL: Reports _____ that there is still evidence of _____ between men and women in the _____.

(9) INFORMAL: You don't have to buy anything if you don't want to.

FORMAL: You are under no _____ to _____ any of our products.

(10) INFORMAL: We'll tell you how you got on in the test in a couple of weeks.

FORMAL: Candidates will be _____ of their results in two weeks.

(11) INFORMAL: If you're not happy with the service in the restaurant you can talk to the manager.

FORMAL: _____ you wish to complain about our service, please contact the manager.

(12) INFORMAL: We're supposed to get there no less than 2 hours before we leave.

FORMAL: Passengers are required to _____ at least 2 hours before _____.

KEY WORD SENTENCE TRANSFORMATION Practice: FORMALITY**[Page 3]**

For each of the sentences below (1 - 10), complete the second sentence so that it has a similar meaning to the first sentence(s), using the word given for that sentence.

DO NOT CHANGE the word given.

You must use between TWO (2) and FIVE (5) words, including the word given.

(1) Sandra would only go to the supermarket on a Saturday.

ON

Sandra _____ to the supermarket on a Saturday.

(2) The contract said that we didn't have to accept the conditions immediately.

OBLIGATION

The contract said that we were _____ accept the conditions immediately.

(3) They say that the new rollercoaster is absolutely terrifying.

SAID

The new rollercoaster _____ absolutely terrifying.

(4) He wouldn't have been interviewed by the police if he hadn't seen the robbery.

WITNESS

The police would not have interviewed him unless he _____ the robbery.

(5) If you need any help please don't hesitate to ask.

ASSISTANCE

If I can _____ please do not hesitate to ask.

(6) The paramedics were told that they should never place a human life at risk trying to rescue an animal.

CIRCUMSTANCES

The paramedics were warned that _____ place a human life at risk attempting to rescue an animal.

(7) If it has to be cancelled the show will take place at a later date.

EVENT

In _____ cancellation, the show will commence at a later date.

(8) The CEO said that, as far as she knows, no one else was involved in the insider trading scandal.

BEST

The CEO said that to the _____ knowledge no one else was involved in the insider trading scandal.

(9) "It's none of your business who I go out with," Suzie told her brother.

CONCERN

Suzie informed her brother that who she went out with was _____ his.

(10) Experts say that teenagers didn't use to be so stressed out.

SUFFER

Experts say that teenagers _____ they did in the past.

You may need to write formal letters (or formal emails) for many different reasons.

Think (1) _____ the types of formal letters you need to write. Your list may include **application letters**, **letters of complaint**, **letters to ask for information**, and **confirmation letters / letters to place or follow up an order or booking**. You may also need to write letters to **apologize**, to **ask for permission** or to give **advice or instructions**.

When writing a formal letter, first ask yourself:

- Who am I writing to?
- Why am I writing?
- What do I need to tell them?
- What do I want them to do?

Where should you start?

1) Make a list (2) _____ all the points you need to include in your letter. Always give precise details, such as exact names, addresses and dates (for example, the date you bought something, or when and where you saw an advertisement). If you have already been in touch (3) _____ the individual or organization, give the dates of any previous letters, phone calls or emails. If you have a reference or account number, always include it in your letter.

2) Put your points (4) _____ order. Decide on the opening sentence: this should state clearly why you are writing. You should also plan how your letter will end. Do you want to emphasize what you want to happen (5) _____ a result of your letter?

3) Make a draft of your letter. Decide (6) _____ the paragraphs you want to use. The first paragraph should probably include your reason (7) _____ writing. The second or other paragraphs may include a summary of details, or an explanation (8) _____ your situation. The last paragraph is often used to state what you want or what you would like to happen next.

4) Read through the draft and edit your writing. Do you want to change the order (9) _____ your points? Is there anything missing?

5) Now proofread (10) _____ grammar, spelling and punctuation.

What is important?

When writing formal letters, you need to make sure your writing is relevant. Formal letters are generally precise and to-the-point, without too much unnecessary detail. When writing a formal letter, such as a letter of complaint, it can sometimes be difficult to adopt the right tone. The tone (11) _____ a letter means how it sounds. It is important to be objective and to sound business-like, rather than allow your feelings get (12) _____ the way. A good way to check the tone is to ask a friend to read it (13) _____ you and say how they would feel if they received it.

In order to have a formal style, you need to think about the layout (14) _____ your letter and the language you use. It is very helpful to look (15) _____ the layout of different kinds of formal letters. You can also build your vocabulary (16) _____ using a dictionary or thesaurus to make a list (17) _____ useful words, phrases and sentences you can use in formal letters.

Use the right tone

A business or formal letter should be written (18) _____ a tone that is slightly more formal than your everyday language. Avoid the following: slang or jargon; contractions such as *I'm*, *can't*, *it's*; and vague words such as *good* and *nice*. Be polite and respectful, even if you are complaining.

The salutation is an important part of a formal letter. The choice of the right salutation depends (19) _____ whether you know the person you are writing to and how formal your relationship is. If and/or when you do not know the name of the person you are writing to there are ONLY 2 ways you may begin the letter: "To Whom It May Concern:" or "Dear Sir/Madam,". DO NOT write to a position (~~Dear Manager~~), DO NOT use titles (~~Director of X Department~~) and NEVER write "Dear Mr. / Mrs." or "Hello" "Hi" "Good morning" "Good afternoon" or "Good evening". Additionally, the phrase "Have a nice day." does not truly belong (20) _____ formal communication.

Academic Vocabulary / Word Formation

Complete the following sentences (1 - 10) by filling in the blank spaces with **the proper form of the word given for that sentence**. Use ONLY ONE word per blank space: DO NOT add any words [e.g. prepositions].

- (1) ADOPT She was homeless and had to put her child up for _____.
- (2) APOLOGIZE He's demanding a full _____ from the newspaper for making untrue allegations about his personal life.
- (3) CLEARLY Could you _____ the first point please? I don't understand it completely.
- (4) COMPLAINT Lots of people have _____ about the noise.
- (5) EMPHASIZE I think we should put as much _____ on preventing disease as we do on curing it.
- (6) EXPLANATION The teacher _____ the rules to the children.
- (7) PREVIOUS She was _____ employed as a tour guide.
- (8) RECEIVED The president gave a _____ for the visiting heads of state.
- (9) RELEVANT I understand what you are saying but I don't understand the _____ to this discussion.
- (10) RESPECTFUL He is very well _____ in the business world.

Prepositions

Complete the following sentences (1 - 10) by filling in the blank spaces with the proper preposition. You may use ONLY ONE word for each blank space.

- (1) The book opens with an explanation _____ why some drugs are banned.
- (2) Your social life must not get _____ the way of your studies.
- (3) I met him when I worked in Madrid, and I've kept in touch _____ him ever since.
- (4) The teacher told us to look _____ the blackboard.
- (5) The police have compiled a list _____ suspects.
- (6) He had cheated in the test _____ using a calculator.
- (7) His blindness is the result _____ an accident.
- (8) All drafts and revisions must be thoroughly proofread _____ typographical, grammatical, and punctuation errors.
- (9) I have asked the secretary to type it out after she has put everything _____ alphabetical order.
- (10) I really like the layout _____ your house.

Explanation "OF" or "FOR" ?

- 1) If you give an **explanation of** something that has happened, you give people reasons for it, especially in an attempt to justify it.

*She told the court she would give a full **explanation of** the prosecution's decision on Monday.*

*There was a hint **of** schoolboy shyness in his **explanation**.*

*'It's my ulcer,' he added by way **of** **explanation**.*

- 2) If you say there is an **explanation for** something, you mean that there is a reason for it.

[You can say there is a reason "why" something happened...but you CANNOT say there is a reason "**for** why" something happened – therefore, you CANNOT really say there is an explanation "**for** why" something happened...should be an explanation "**of** why" something happened.]

*The deputy airport manager said there was no apparent **explanation for** the crash.*

*Scientific **explanations for** natural phenomena are widely accepted.*

*It's the only **explanation for** these results.*

*He had no **explanation for** his absence the day before.*

- 3) If you give an explanation of something, you give details about it or describe it so that it can be understood.

*Haig was immediately impressed by Charteris's expertise and by his lucid **explanation of** the work.*

*She gave a detailed **explanation of** the administration's health-care proposal.*

- 4) Other

*The judge didn't believe his **explanation that** he had stolen the money in order to give it to charity.*

READING COMPREHENSION PRACTICE:

[Page 6]

Read the following passage - then choose the best answer (a, b, c or d) for each of the questions below (1 - 10).

Right now, I am looking at a shelf full of **relics, a collection of has-beens, old-timers, antiques, fossils**. Right now I am looking at a shelf full of books. Yes, that's right. If you have some spare cash (the going rate is about \$89) and are looking to enhance your reading experience, then I highly suggest you consider purchasing an e-reader. E-readers are replacing the books of old, and I welcome them with open arms (as you should).

If you haven't heard of an e-reader and don't know what it is, then please permit the following explanation. An e-reader is a device that allows you to read e-books. An e-book is a book-length publication in digital form, consisting of text, images, or both, and produced on, published through, and readable on computers or other electronic devices. Sometimes the equivalent of a conventional printed book, e-books can also be born digital. The Oxford Dictionary of English defines the e-book as "an electronic version of a printed book," but e-books can and do exist without any printed equivalent.

So now you know what an e-reader is. But you still may be wondering why they **put printed books to shame**. E-readers are superior to printed books because they save space, are environmentally friendly, and provide helpful reading tips and tools that printed books do not.

E-readers are superior to printed books because they save space. The average e-reader can store thousands of digital books, providing a veritable library at your fingertips. What is more, being the size and weight of a thin hardback, the e-reader itself is relatively **petite**. It is easy to hold and can fit in a pocketbook or briefcase easily. This makes handling ponderous behemoths such as War and Peace, Anna Karenina, and Les Misérables a breeze. Perhaps the only drawback to the space-saving aspect of an e-reader is that it requires you to find new things to put on your shelves.

In addition, e-readers are superior to books because they are environmentally friendly. The average novel is about 300 pages long. So, if a novel is printed 1000 times, it will use 300,000 pieces of paper. That's a lot of paper! If there are about 80,000 pieces of paper in a tree, this means it takes almost 4 trees to make these 1000 books. Now, we know that the average bestseller sells about 20,000 copies per week. That means that it takes over 300 trees each month to **sustain** this rate. And for the super bestsellers, these figures increase dramatically. For example, the Harry Potter book series has sold over 450 million copies. That's about 2 million trees! Upon viewing these figures, it is not hard to grasp the severe impact of printed books on the environment. Since e-readers use no trees, they represent a significant amount of preservation in terms of the environment and its resources.

Finally, e-readers are superior to books because they provide helpful reading tips and tools that printed books do not. The typical e-reader allows its user to customize letter size, font, and line spacing. It also allows highlighting and electronic bookmarking. Furthermore, it grants users the ability to get an overview of a book and then jump to a specific location based on that overview. While these are all nice features, perhaps the most helpful of all is the ability to get dictionary definitions at the touch of a finger. On even the most basic e-reader, users can conjure instant definitions without having to hunt through a physical dictionary.

It can be seen that e-readers are superior to printed books. They save space, are environmentally friendly, and provide helpful reading tips and tools that printed books do not. So what good are printed books? Well, they certainly make nice decorations.

(1) As used in paragraph 1, it can be inferred that "**relics,**" "**has-beens, old-timers, antiques, fossils**" are all words that describe something

- a) ...ancient. b) ...useless. c) ...outdated. d) ...pathetic.

(2) The tone of the author can best be described as...

- a) ...shrewd. b) ...conniving. c) ...persuasive. d) ...authoritative.

- (3) According to the author, e-books...
 I. ...were all once printed books.
 II. ...may be "born digital".
 III. ...are able to display images.
 a) I only b) I and II only c) II and III only d) I, II, and III
- (4) As used in paragraph 3, which of the following describes something that has been **"put to shame"**?
 a) A dog is left outside on a frigid, dreary winter night.
 b) Team A defeats Team B in a humiliating rout.
 c) Martha is caught stealing at the mall and is arrested in front of a crowd of curious bystanders.
 d) The machine has countless moving parts, and Dustin has trouble assembling it.
- (5) A thesis statement is a sentence that clearly describes what the author plans to discuss. Based on this information, which of the following sentences from the passage is the thesis statement?
 a) If you have some spare cash (the going rate is about \$89) and are looking to enhance your reading experience, then I highly suggest you consider purchasing an e-reader.
 b) E-readers are replacing the books of old, and I welcome them with open arms (as you should).
 c) An e-reader is a device that allows you to read e-books. An e-book is a book-length publication in digital form, consisting of text, images, or both, and produced on, published through, and readable on computers or other electronic devices.
 d) E-readers are superior to printed books because they save space, are environmentally friendly, and provide helpful reading tips and tools that printed books do not.
- (6) Based on its use in paragraph 4, it can be inferred that **petite** belongs to which of the following word families?
 a) jubilant, euphoric, playful b) compact, diminutive, little
 c) cute, attractive, charming d) light, airy, spacious
- (7) Based on information in the passage, it can be inferred that War and Peace, Anna Karenina, and Les Misérables are all...
 a) ...authored by Europeans. b) ...dense and impenetrable.
 c) ...timeless classics. d) ...awkward or unwieldy.
- (8) As used in paragraph 5, which is the best synonym for **sustain**?
 a) maintain b) allow c) enforce d) yield
- (9) According to the author, which of the following reading tips and tools are offered by the e-reader?
 I. line spacing customization
 II. the ability to quickly jump to the end of a book
 III. access to an online thesaurus at the touch of a finger
 a) I only b) I and II only c) II and III only d) I, II, and III
- (10) Which of the following best describes the organization of this passage?
 a) introduction, thesis statement, supporting paragraphs, conclusion
 b) history, thesis statement, supporting paragraphs, conclusion
 c) advertisement, background, introduction, supporting paragraphs, examples, conclusion
 d) introduction, background, thesis statement, supporting paragraphs, conclusion